

Atonal music

This excerpt from Liszt's *Bagatelle Without Tonality* is atonal, it does not have a key signature, and the notes C and A do not feature prominently enough to show whether the music is in C major or A minor. There are also lots of accidentals, none of which lead the music toward a definite key.

▽ Liszt's *Bagatelle Without Tonality*

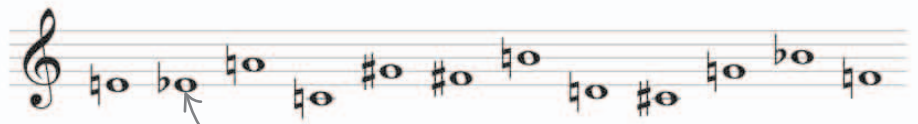
The excerpt below shows that this piece is atonal. There is no key signature or keynote, and the accidentals are not related to any obvious key.



LOOKING CLOSER

Serialism

Some atonal music is composed using a serialist or a 12-tone technique. Serialism involves putting the 12 different notes of the chromatic scale into a chosen order. This is called a tone row. The notes of a serialist piece follow the order of the tone row on which the piece is based.



The tone row includes a nonrepetitive ordering of all the notes of the chromatic scale.

66 △ **Tone row**
Shown here is an example of a tone row, with the 12 different notes of the chromatic scale in an order that is seemingly random, but is in fact fixed.



E is the first note of the tone row.

After all 12 notes of the tone row have been heard, E returns.

△ **Melody based on tone row**
This melody uses the notes of the tone row shown above, in the exact same order.